

FEAR OF MISSING OUT AND SOCIAL MEDIA USE

Fear of Missing Out and Social Media Use

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Abstract

This literature review integrates six empirical studies that explore psychological, developmental, and sociocultural factors related to problematic social media use with special attention to the fear of missing out (FoMo). Personality traits predicted higher engagement, but these effects weakened once FoMo was included in the models. Evidence suggests that FoMo contributes to problematic use by undermining self-regulation, while experimental findings show that reducing screen time can lower depression and FoMo among young adults. Other studies highlight additional influences. Depression emerged as the strongest predictor of problematic use in cross-national data sets, and a 15-year-long longitudinal study associating low parental monitoring during adolescence with increased risk of social media addiction in adulthood. FoMo also appears to be shaped by familial values, with Latinx college students reporting influence patterns. Overall, the literature identifies FoMo as a key factor in problematic social media use while emphasizing the roles of self-regulation, mental health, and cultural context.

Keywords: fear of missing out, problematic social media use, social media addiction, self-regulation, and mental health

Fear of Missing Out and Social Media Use

Social media use has become a near-universal phenomenon among young adults, with billions of active users worldwide. Current research suggests that roughly 15% to 20% of people may engage with social media in ways that are potentially problematic across different cultural contexts (Li et al., 2025; Nurmala et al., 2025). Problematic social media use generally refers to compulsive patterns of use that interfere with everyday functioning, including work, sleep, and relationships. The six studies reviewed in this paper aim to deepen understanding of what contributes to this pattern. This is achieved by reviewing potential influential factors such as personality traits, fear of missing out, parental relationships, mental health, and cultural identity.

Personality and Attachment Predictors

Individual differences in personality and attachment styles have been widely studied as predictors of social media use. Blackwell et al. (2017) examined how extraversion, neuroticism, anxious, and avoidant attachment styles related to general social media engagement and addictive use among 207 participants. Extraversion and neuroticism were connected to higher overall engagement, and neuroticism also predicted addictive use in the earlier stages of analysis. Anxious and avoidant attachments were significant at intermediate steps of the research as well. Once fear of missing out (FoMo) was added to the final model, it became the only significant predictor of addiction, and the effects of personality and attachment were no longer significant. This suggests that while personality and attachment can influence how people initially use social media, FoMo is the more direct factor that turns frequent use into compulsive behavior.

Vernon et al. (2024) built on this idea by studying 452 Latinx college students and investigating whether dark triad traits were related to FoMo and social media addiction. Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychopathy were all examined, but only Machiavellianism

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showed a meaningful relationship with FoMo. The authors suggested that people higher in Machiavellian traits are more likely to strategically monitor others, which aligns with the constant checking and comparison that often occur on social media. In their sample, social media addiction was also strongly linked to FoMo, which suggests that these two aspects may reinforce each other over time. Greater FoMo can lead to compulsive use, which can then intensify that fear.

Fear of Missing Out and Self-Control Failure

Li et al. (2025) further clarified how FoMo translates into problematic social media use in a three-wave study of 520 Chinese university students conducted over six months. The authors separated FoMo into two forms. One reflected a stable tendency to feel left out. The other reflected short-term feelings tied to current situations. Both predicted higher levels of problematic social media use. The key finding is that both forms of FoMo led students to struggle with limiting their time on social media. The worry caused by FoMo makes self-regulation more difficult, and many students end up using platforms longer than intended. This pattern appeared not only in differences between students, but also within the same students over time. Together, these findings suggest that both stable traits and short-term emotional shifts can contribute to compulsive social media use.

Mental Health, Experimental Evidence, and Cultural Context

Psychological Distress as a Predictor

A clear pattern across the literature is the connection between depressive symptoms and problematic social media use. In a study of more than 1,400 university students in Indonesia and Taiwan, Nurmala et al. (2025) examined both general compulsive social media use and platform-specific use of YouTube. Across both samples, depression surfaced as the strongest

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predictor of each type, outranking anxiety and stress. The authors suggest that this relationship can be understood through a theoretical framework that links mood and executive control.

Individuals experiencing depression may turn to social media to cope with negative emotions, but reduced self-regulatory capacity can cause that use to be repetitive and self-reinforcing.

Cultural contexts also shape these patterns. Indonesian students reported higher levels of general compulsive use, while Taiwanese students showed greater problematic use with YouTube specifically.

Vernon et al. (2024) reported a similar pattern among Latinx college students, finding that depression was a significant predictor of FoMo. When individuals feel persistently low, they may become more observant of others' behavior and perceive exclusion. Together, these studies suggest that depression plays a central role in both problematic social media engagement and FoMo across different cultural groups.

Effects of Reducing Social Media Use

Davis and Goldfield (2025) reported compelling findings from a randomized controlled trial involving 220 young adults aged 17 to 25 who reported experiencing emotional distress. Participants were randomly assigned to either restrict their daily social media use to 1 hour or maintain their normal usage patterns for 3 weeks. Those who restricted their use scored favorably on scales of depression, anxiety, and FoMo. The restricted group also reported longer sleep duration compared to the control group. Importantly, social media use was tracked using objective measures built into the device rather than relying on self-reported data, thereby strengthening credibility.

One noteworthy finding was the strong correlation between social media use and FoMo. Reduction in use correlated with lower levels of FoMo, suggesting a cycle in which heavy use

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heightens the fear of exclusion, which, in turn, motivates further engagement. Simultaneously, the authors caution that all participants entered the study with pre-existing psychological distress, limiting the generalizability of these findings.

Developmental and Sociocultural Factors

Parental Relationships in Adolescence

Demers et al. (2025) tracked 322 participants at ages 15, 25, and 30 to determine whether adolescent family relationships leave lasting effects on adult social media behavior. Structural equation modeling indicated that low parental modeling at age 15 predicted addiction at age 30, with greater chat site activity in adolescence and elevated platform use at 25 serving as two mediating steps. In addition, elevated parental conflict in adolescence directly predicted adult addiction, but this effect did not follow the same escalation pathway.

The authors suggest that conflict at home may push adolescents to seek emotional support or to escape online, behaviors that persist into adulthood. Because the study tracked participants over 15 years, it provides rare longitudinal evidence that early family dynamics can shape behavior through adolescence and beyond.

Cultural Contexts and Familial Values

Vernon et al. (2025) addressed a gap in the literature by exploring familistic values among Latinx students. Familial honor was positively associated with FoMo, suggesting that concern for social standing extends to platform monitoring. Conversely, familial connectedness and ethnic social relations were negatively associated, suggesting that strong ties with family and community can provide the satisfaction needed to curb social media monitoring. These findings raise questions about whether FoMo frameworks developed in one culture can apply to populations where family and community ties carry different meanings.

Conclusion

Across diverse methods and populations, the six reviewed studies converge on FoMo as the significant driver of problematic social media use, consistently outranking personality and attachment variables once introduced (Blackwell et al., 2017). Its influence operates partly through self-regulation. When people experience FoMo, it becomes harder to limit time spent on platforms (Li et al., 2025). Depression is also a piece of this cycle. It both predicts heavier social media use and appears to worsen with it, while experimental evidence shows that intentionally reducing social media can lead to improvements in mood (Davis & Goldfield, 2025; Nurmala et al., 2025).

Developmental and cultural factors further complicate these patterns. Longitudinal evidence suggests that early family dynamics can shape later digital behavior, with lower parental monitoring in adolescence predicted a greater risk of social media addiction in adulthood (Demers et al., 2025). Cultural context also matters. Research conducted with Latinx students suggests that how FoMo is experienced reflects one's family obligations and community ties.

However, the current literature has a few limitations. Three of the six studies relied on cross-sectional designs, which limits the ability to make causal conclusions, and some samples were demographically small. Future research would benefit from more experimental and long-term longitudinal studies with diverse populations. These designs would clarify whether interventions that directly target FoMo, rather than just reducing overall screen time, lead to lasting reductions in problematic social media use.

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